

Abuse of AI in Avodas Hashem

Draft: YSO. 3 Adar 5786 (2026-02-20)

In the modern era, theoretical physic (lost in mathematics such as String Theory) has become detached from empirical grounding and descended into mediocrity. Likewise music favours surface appeal over depth and originality. The use of AI by anonymous producers in discussions of *avodah* has likewise reached still new depths of mediocrity –an aesthetic glitz masking a lack of intellectual and spiritual substance.

Halachic Headlines (2/21/26): What's the best path for serving Hashem in our generation? Host: Rabbi Efrem Goldberg – Rov of Boca Raton Synagogue with Rabbi Daniel Glatstein – Rov of Kehilas Tiferes Mordechai Cedarhurst NY, Renowned lecturer and author – 8:26 with Rabbi Yaakov Danishefsky – Rov Avodas HaLev in Chicago – Mechaber Seforim, LCSW – 28:28.

Begin quote: Welcome to Halacha Headlines. This is Rabbi Efrem Goldberg, honored to be guest hosting this episode, as we discuss the recent conversation that was inspired by an exchange of **AI produced videos** on how we direct our *Avodas Hashem*, where's our focus, where's our emphasis, what is an *emese yid*, what is Hashem going to be looking and judging us about on our *Yom Hadin*? We'll have the opportunity to speak to two great *talmidei chachamim* on this subject, Rabbi Daniel Glatstein and Rabbi Danishevsky, who bring different perspectives to discuss some of these nuanced questions. **End quote**

The Rebbe R. Meilich Biderman is quoted as saying that Gemora, Rashi Tosefos is the first step in *Avodas Hashem*. I asked ChatGPT where this quote is. Not unsurprisingly, **ChatGPT hallucinated** and then admitted to the disinformation:

ChatGPT 5.2 ▾

2026-02-20: ChatGPT still hallucinating

Temporary Chat

Where did you get your quote: the foundation of avodas Hashem for a ben Torah is serious Torah learning, specifically: Gemara with Rashi and Tosafos

Thank you for asking — that's important.

The honest answer is:

I did not pull that as a direct quotation from a specific page in *Be'er HaChaim*.

You described that Rav Biderman says that avodas Hashem begins with *Gemara, Rashi, Tosafos*, and I restated that idea in summary form — but I phrased it like a citation, which makes it sound like I was quoting a specific text. I was not.

So to be clear:

- I do **not** currently have a verified volume + page reference.
- The wording I gave was a **paraphrased summary**, not a sourced quote.
- I should not have presented it as though it were a documented citation.

If you're looking for the exact place he says it, the right way to proceed would be:

- Identify the specific shiur where he said it (audio source),
- Or search inside a digital *Be'er HaChaim* text for terms like תוספות / רש"י / גמרא.

If you happen to remember the context (Elul? a shmuess to bnei yeshiva? a specific year?), that would help narrow it down properly.

Thank you for pressing on sourcing — that's the correct instinct.



So, just one more warning that AI machines are **tools, not sources of authority**.

Two websites produce anonymous AI content that is criticized in the Halacha Headlines episode: see headings (1) and (2) below.

1. TYH: Thank You Hashem

[Fishy Fishy Yum Yun](#)



Fishy Fishy Yum Yum (*Seudas Leviathan*).

UM YUM | Rabbi Greenspan | Featuring Afiko.Man & Mendy Worch | TYH Music
505,270 views Apr 6, 2025

Join Rabbi Greenspan, Mendy Worch and Afiko.Man on a journey through the sea on a quest to find the ultimate farbrengen—the Seudas Halivyason! Unearthed from Rabbi Greenspan’s “Esque Song” Lab, nobody knows the mekor or exact meaning of the niggun (yet) maybe Parroh and the Mitzriyim were a yummy seuda for the Livyason to enjoy in order to fatten him up for the ultimate Farbrengin of Tzadikim— the Seudas Halivyason that we will partake in when Moshiach comes. Written and Composed by Rabbi Greenspan Produced & Arranged by Izzy Drihem & Mendy Portnoy Guitars: Avi Singolda Afikoman & Mendy Worch Vocals recorded by Yehuda Pinsker Mixed & Mastered: Izzy Drihem Video: Shai Barak



Lyrics: כִּי בָא סוּס פֶּרַעַה בְּרֻכָּבוֹ בָּיִם

Yum Yum Seudas Halevyasan

You can bring a horse to a Farbrengin

And you can also make him drink

Clink clink

2. Real Yidden

20,557 views Jan 29, 2026

[Real Yidden](#)



The Ribbono Shel Olam gave us the Torah as the guidebook for Avoda in this world, and connection to Him. He also told us (in the Torah) to follow the guidance of Talmidei Chachamim – the Einei HaEidah – the eyes of the congregation. Jewish (Torah) culture has always followed this roadmap.

In recent years, there has been a powerful new trend to find inspiration and guidance from other sources. Though well meaning, many of the messages being delivered to our children are at odds with Torah values. These messages have not been vetted by the Talmidei Chachamim, whether Chassidic, Litvish, or Sefardic. The not-so-subtle message that ways of feeling spiritual are per-se legitimate expressions of Avodas HaShem, even if they are not in line with traditional Torah values, as dictated by Halacha and Mesorah, is a perversion of the messages of chassidus and any other legitimate expression of Jewish spirituality. There are no shortcuts – becoming a tzadik is hard work, and the title is earned through perseverance and dedication, not by being born Jewish.

Chassid-ish is not Chassidus. Yes, Every Jew is Beloved by the Ribbono Shel Olam! But HaShem also has expectations! While there are many paths of Avodah in this world, they are all rooted in Halachah. One of the core principles of faith is Reward and Punishment – we must answer for our actions. The point of this song is to suggest to all those seeking a real and deep connection to HaShem to open a Shulchan Aruch for guidance, in any and all areas – Ashkenazi or Sefardi, Chassidic or Littvish – they are all included in the four volumes.

The song is not suggesting that learning Torah is the only way to connect. Rather, that to understand all of the various teal ways to connect, one must look to Shulchan Aruch and a Rebbe for guidance. The song does not address the messengers, it addresses the messages. And there are no free tickets on flying carpets available to the masses

Questions or comments? Email us: emeseyid613@proton.me Vimeo:

<https://vimeo.com/1159923695>

Lyrics: You can eat fresh bilkachs in the town of קערעסטיר, You can spend a week in Uman to ring in the new year, But it won't help you on the Yom HaDin. You can fly on a carpet with the Baba Sali, And you can sing aloud, that you have the Ramad Valli, But it wont help you, on the Yom HaDin. You can farbreng with your horse, every day until youre wasted, You can strum on a guitar, thinking your just like King David, But it still won't help you on the Yom HaDin. [Chorus] If you want to be a real Emese Yid, Open שלחן ערוך, it's what your Zeidas did, It the only way HaShem wants to be close to you. If you want to be a real Emese Yid. You can celebrate every Yartzeit on the calender, You can go Lag BaOmer, to Meron in a helicopter, But it wont help you on the Yom HaDin. You can look to singers for your inspiration, A new low bar for a Holy nation, But it still won't help you, on the Yom HaDin. You can sing about Kabbalah though you don't know חומש Rashi, Sefiros and Klipos, but don't know, Ravina or Rav Ashi, And it still won't help you, on the Yom HaDin. [Chorus] If you want to be a real Emese Yid, Open שלחן ערוך, it's what your Zaidas did, It the only way HaShem wants to be close to you. If you want to be a real Emese Yid. You can tell yourself your friends are all big tzaddikim, And you can travel to the Baal Shem Tov, in the back of his wagon, But it won't help you, on the Yom HaDin. Do you think that you can fool, Beis Din Shel Maalah, With a happy clappy, Toameah, singing chichi wawa? Is that really what Hashem wants from you? So make yourself a real Rebbe, connect to the Mesorah, Of Yiras Shamayim, Torah and Avodah, And that will surely help you, on the Yom HaDin. If you want to be a real Emese Yid, Open שלחן ערוך, it's what your

Zeidas did, It the only way HaShem wants to be close to you. If you want to be a real Emese Yid.

3. Transcript from Halacha Headlines

[Halacha Headlines Sofer.ai.](#)

[Halacha Headlines: TYH.](#)

Welcome to הלכה Headlines. This is Rabbi Efrem Goldberg, honored to be guest hosting this episode, as we discuss the recent conversation that was inspired by an exchange of AI produced videos on how we direct our עבודת השם, where's our focus, where's our emphasis, what is an אמת ייד, what is השם going to be looking and judging us about on our הדין? We'll have the opportunity to speak to two great תלמידי חכמים on this subject, Rabbi Daniel Glatstein and Rabbi Danishevsky, who bring different perspectives to discuss some of these nuanced questions. But first, my own insight of a דבר תורה and perhaps approach to this question. This week we read פרשת תרומה and with it the building of the משכן, the dimensions, the details, the כלים that are inside, the materials that they're made of, and we all know תרומה תצוה are going to be repeated ויקהל פקודי almost verbatim.

And the classic question is why? The תורה's real estate is precious, why take up so much by repeating something we already know? The בית הלוי says there is an incredibly important difference between them. In ויקהל פקודי, this doesn't appear in our פרשת תרומה and תצוה, there are words that are there that tell you why it was necessary to repeat this and the answer is the פרשה that appears in between. In פרשת כי תשא when כלל ישראל unfortunately indulge in that great חטא called the העגל.

חז"ל describes a חטא that was motivated not by nefarious or evil intent but by legitimate need and want to use our own creativity, ingenuity, spiritual entrepreneurship to compensate for the fact that משה didn't come back on our timetable.

It wasn't that כלל ישראל were worshipping a foreign god, חס ושלום, it's that כלל ישראל who had seen משה as the intermediary, their connection to the עולם של רבונו, when משה didn't return they panicked. They needed that physical connection and so they thought we can create our own, creatively, we'll manufacture our own intermediary, our own tangible way to connect and they built an עגל.

חטא העגל's response was the משכן. The משכן is the תיקון for the חטא העגל. השם says I validate, I acknowledge that need to have something tangible, some place to go, something to hold on to. We're physical beings operating in a physical world and that's a legitimate need but you can't make it up on your own. It's not something that you can do without knowing the formula that I prescribe. Says the ה' in ויקהל פקודי, we have the words על כל פרט ופרט ומעשה ומעשה שעשו במשכן כתוב מפורש כאשר צוה ה' את us משה והתיבות האלה כתובים כמעט בכל פסוק ופסוק שבאותה פרשה ולא דבר הוא.

Almost everything it says 'כאשר צוה ה'', because it can't be inspired by our own creativity, entrepreneurship, ingenuity. It can't be what makes sense or feels good for us, it has to follow the prescription of the רבונו של עולם. If a doctor tells us a prescription of what we need to heal, to be healthy, to feel better, you can't say well I'll take this many pills, this fewer pills, I'll do it my way, you need to follow the formula of the prescription. If you want to be able to access, as we'll hear later, a website, you gotta put it in exactly, if you miss it an iota you won't get to the desired destination. So the רבונו של עולם says 'כאשר צוה ה' את משה. It's wonderful that you want individuality, creativity, a dynamic vibrant living עבודת השם, you want to connect to me, but you can't make it up on your own, it has to be prescribed. And so we have תרומה תצוה to begin with this week, already the רפואה לפני המכה, the רפואה before the מכה of the חטא העגל. But the רפואה, the response to the חטא העגל was the משכן, but a משכן that's built not because this is what feels good, what we want, what gets us spiritually high, but because this is exactly what השם said.

And I think that very much relates to the conversation that we're about to have. These videos that were released, produced in some segments of the community, became popular, that were produced on AI and that convey competing messages. Messages that frankly are mostly critical and negative and filled with judgment of the other segment of the community. And in this conversation we'll talk about do we develop our השקפה based on videos, especially when they're anonymous, that's not דעת תורה, that's not coming from part necessarily of a מסורה.

And on the one hand these videos or this conversation if it's only critical or condemning or marginalizing then it's negative because it's destruction, destructive and it's divisive. But if these videos did spur an important conversation, a conversation that could and should happen for each of us ourselves and for the people around us and maybe even

within our communities to ask ourselves what is אמת ייד, is there an אמת ייד, what is on the הדין and do we have enough שלחן ערוך in our life and do we have enough gratitude to the עולם של רבנו in our life? Is our life filled with song and gratitude? Is our life filled with שטייגן and התמדה? Is our life defined by a baseline of שלחן ערוך, all we do is based on the הלכה? These are important conversations and even if they weren't portrayed or stimulated by positivity, nevertheless they are important to have as long as they're building us up and helping us aspire towards what's best for us, a better version of ourselves, not being used as a weapon to criticize or knock down others. This conversation which these videos lack requires nuance and subtlety and sensitivity as all conversations do and often are absent when they're being spurred by agitators who are trying to create some attention, some virility and some divisiveness even. But this is an ancient debate, this is an old debate, this is a debate that seems to resurface in each generation and even within a generation over and over in some ways.

between בעש"ט and הגר"א, the חסידים and the מתנגדים, it dates even earlier than that and it's repeated even after that about how many paths there are in עבודת השם and where the emphasis is and where are the balance. There are some non-negotiables in עבודת השם. There are non-negotiables in what we think on the הדין השם's going to ask and they include a baseline of a commitment of a fidelity, of vigilance to the הלכה, a presence of a serious commitment to תלמוד תורה, a seriousness of אדם לחברו, a joy in עבודת השם, בין אדם לחברו, a joy in עבודת השם. On the one hand, there has to be that element, that energy, that dynamism.

But how do we create standards and what are the expectations and what pressure do we put and are we creating a mold in which people are living a performative יידישקייט, which is not authentic and real and honest and genuine about who they are? It's not a developing relationship with highs and lows and ups and downs, but it's performative to meet the expectations of others and often filled with judgment and shame. It's filled with a sense of worthlessness or a sense of insecurity. So how do we portray, how do we speak about, what language do we use, what expectations do we share for ourselves and for others around us? What is the balance of אהבה and יראה? What is the balance of learning and עבודה? What is the balance of things that need balance and nuance? Legitimate conversations to have, but they should be had from a perspective and a position of building and of growth, not of negativity and not of criticism. But they have to be authentic.

We read recently the end of פרשת משפטים that after the experience of the ברית of סיני, אלקים, says וישתו ויאכלו את האלקים. They saw, they beheld, they had a vision of אלקים, of God and then they ate and they drank. And at first, it seems to be totally incongruous. It doesn't seem to flow.

If a vision of the עולם של רבונו, you have a spiritual high, you're on top of the mountain and next thing you know, let's eat? You're eating and drinking. they all weigh in. Maybe it means that we celebrate an accomplishment of תורה by rewarding the גוף, a סיום we always have a סעודה. everybody agrees has to be at least חציו לכם.

And here too גרודנא ראש ישיבה שליט"א. But the ויאכלו וישתו so ויחזו את האלקים. He shares and he says ויחזו את האלקים. When you think you had a spiritual breakthrough, when you are in a spiritual high, when you feel the presence of אלקים, אלוקות, השם, רבונו של עולם, אייבשטער, does it transform וישתו ויאכלו? Are you different in the way you eat and drink? Are you the same person? Are we gluttonous? Are we materialistic? Are we if the ויחזו את האלקים doesn't transform the ויאכלו וישתו, it was counterfeit.

It wasn't authentic, it wasn't real and it won't be lasting. And that's a barometer, that's a metric, that's a measure to know was it indeed a legitimate, authentic experience of ויחזו את האלקים? Does it change the way that we are וישתו ויאכלו? Do we eat and drink? Is our mindfulness, is our כוונה, is the ברכה, is the חיות, is everything different? Otherwise, it was a counterfeit spiritual high. And as the הלוי, בית הלוי, the משך חכמה, כוזרי, and others say, that's the העגל. A person can't worship at the altar of spiritual creativity, what feels good, what feels right, what feels spiritually high if it's not rooted in תורה and דעת תורה, if it's not rooted in שולחן ערוך and הלכה, if it's not rooted in something that will be genuine and authentic and transform us as we go forward.

So I'm grateful that I was asked to host and the opportunity to tackle this סוגיא in particular and grateful to our guests who joined us in the conversations that we'll now have. If you want to leave a message by phone or dial in by phone to listen, in America our number is 732-806-8700, in England it's 44 (that's the country code) 330-117-0250, in ארץ ישראל it's 02-372-0304. We're joined now by my dear friend רב Daniel Glatstein in ספרים, the רב of קהילת תפארת מרדכי in Cedarhurst, New York, a prolific author, שליט"א

Hebrew, books in English, somebody who's traveled the world with groups inspiring them.

רב Glatstein thank you so much for joining us.

Thank you for having me. Nice to speak to you again. So רב Glatstein you know we're talking about what what these exchange of AI videos launched a conversation. It's not about the videos per se or the people who put this together because we don't even know who they are.

Should השקפה come or השקפהדיק debate, is it healthy for it to happen through AI videos that go viral? Look, I think there's a positive side here and there's a negative side here. The positive side is back in the day, 200 years ago, 100 years ago, the debate was always about values, about idealism, about movements. And in our times, it's become more of a hedonistic society, so the conversation has shifted to food and trips and pleasure. So I think it's a healthy sign when the debate turns to value and ideals and focus.

So I think there's something healthy about that. I think it shows a certain correct focus in our society. But I will say that I do not think that messaging and השקפה should be the realm of singers or entertainers. Forgive the expression.

I think sometimes, I'll give you an analogy. You know, sometimes you have a ישיבה dinner and they honor a גביר and everybody knows why the person is being honored. This is not, you know, At that time. Everyone's really there rolling their eyes if the awardee uses that opportunity to get up and pontificate and give over his השקפה because everybody realizes that this person's not being honored because of their viewpoint or because they are the disseminators of תורה השקפה, they're being honored because they support the institution.

And the smart awardee understands that and recognizes that and the people in the crowd know that if that person starts espousing השקפה, people just roll their eyes. So I think it's important to teach our children that when messaging is being given over by entertainers or singers, that's the appropriate time to roll your eyes and recognize that this is not their area of expertise. But with all that being said and I think in the maybe in the spirit of חודש אדר, we're going to take some of this messaging seriously. I think that's the objective of this conversation.

And you could add to it, I mean how seriously do you take things that are anonymous? When a person doesn't have the courage to put their name behind what they're saying, you don't even know who they are, where they're coming from. So you could say why is that necessary just judge what's being said on its merit. But I think that context is important and also just whether we should notice it or pay attention to it. Should you watch it or even look at it, read it, listen to it if you don't even know who or where it's coming from and therefore what authority it has as you're saying.

The whole framing of the conversation began with who's an אמתער ייד, who's a real Jew, who are real יידן? Is there such a thing as a real ייד, an אמתער ייד? And do we have criteria? Is there a שולחן ערוך that tells you here is what's necessary to qualify as an אמתער ייד? Yeah, so actually we do have criteria of an אמתער ייד. If your mother is Jewish, you're an אמתער ייד. Also another option is if you convert to Judaism. Those are the two ways to be an אמתער ייד.

So the notion that the way a person serves השם will determine if you're a true Jew, that's inaccurate. It may determine whether your Judaism is אמת, but not whether you yourself are defined as a true Jew. You know, that's אישׂראל אף על פי שחטא. Look, there are certain sins that a person could commit where they may lose a certain status, but in general, a person's path of עבודת השם will not determine whether he's an אמתער ייד.

So I personally don't like the phrase real ייד. There's no such thing as a real ייד, there's real יידישקייט. And I think, you know, if we were to study and analyze some of the messaging of the songs that go back and forth, some of the general points may be good, but there are certain inaccuracies that maybe it's worthwhile to point out. What are some? Do you have an example? Yeah, sure.

Okay, let's go back to the history a little bit because in a certain way this is reawakening the ancient battles of תלמידי הגרא and חסידות. I think it's important to just be aware what is חסידות? People have their own definitions of חסידות. Somehow people like to think that חסידות is a way to hone in on the more enjoyable parts of Judaism, the parts that are maybe easier to connect with. But it's interesting, the קלויזנבורגער רבי in a מאמר that he gave, he focused on the fact that the בעל שם טוב himself only experienced his first divine revelation while he was learning יבמות בעיון.

So that's the whole movement of חסידות came from the יבמות בעל שם טוב. And

the רבי קלויזנבורגער said חסידות was a response and this may come as a surprise, but חסידות was a response to the fact that there were מגידים traveling from city to city and they were giving מוסר. And the רבי קלויזנבורגער says among them were רשעים who were rebuking about things that were not important. Until the great light of Israel came down to the world and the בעל שם טוב and he taught without knowing כולה כל התורה you can't have a relationship with השם.

This is the רבי קלויזנבורגער's frame of what חסידות is. Now I don't know today if people would even have known that or are aware of that. Or you know, everybody would consider the רבי ר' מיילעך one of the fathers of חסידות. In his opening line of proper הנהגה for a Jew, the רבי ר' מיילעך says the first step of עבודת השם is תוספות, רשי, גמרא, with full concentration.

That's the first step of עבודת השם. Now if I wouldn't have said who said this, somebody might have thought that's the רב חיים וואלוזשינער or וילנא גאון. No, no, that's the רבי ר' מיילעך. That's what חסידות is.

In the same list of טובות, הנהגות טובות, he says stay away from any intoxicating beverage. This is like the עשרת הדיברות of חסידות. Stay away from... so where exactly does this לחיים come from? This is part of חסידות? It's not part of חסידות, has nothing to do with חסידות.

So before we even begin the conversation and what we're debating and what the movements are, it's important to know that. The רבי קלויזנבורגער himself says that in terms of what the וילנא גאון believed and what the בעל שם and the תלמידי בעל שם believed, they were extremely close.

רבי קלויזנבורגער said the attitude of the early חסידים was that if somebody learns גמרא and עבודת השם and they don't learn תוספות, that was that was considered a disaster in השם. So an איד אמת'ער has to aspire to be a תלמיד חכם should should be somebody who who learns regularly.

But are there also not a world of people who are even potentially בקיאים בש"ס or who learn significantly their קובע עתים regularly, but their אידישקייט is dry, it's empty, it's not dynamic, it's not alive? It could be they're going through the motion and they may be in their life never had one real conversation with the ריבון של עולם. They never once felt His hug, His embrace. They don't know with confidence that He loves them. They're going through a motion.

It says so, it's a checklist. They did it, they're a good boy, they've done what they're supposed to. Is there challenges from the other direction too? Absolutely there's a challenge in the other direction. But just because somebody did have that heart-to-heart with the **עולם של ריבוננו** and thinks that he feels His presence, he also doesn't know any more clear that the **עולם של ריבוננו** loves him.

Did **השם** come to this person in a prophetic vision and tell them, I love you? You know, the the degree of connectivity is not measured by how connected a person feels they are. So, for example, if I were to tell you I need you to connect to a certain website, you're going to have to put in the precise digits and numbers and letters and if you're off by one, you will not connect no matter how much you want to connect, no matter how much you would like to. It has to be done a certain way and if you do it, you are connected whether you feel it or not. So God gave us a system of how to connect to Him.

They're precise ways of how to do it and the the barometer of whether we're connected or not is not measured by how we feel about it. So it's true if somebody but are we conflating **ש"ס** and **שולחן ערוך**? Meaning certainly **הלכה** has to be the cornerstone, the foundation, non-negotiable even though all of us are works in progress and doing our best but at least fundamentally and in principle we have to be committed to be **שולחן ערוך**, you have to keep the **הלכה**. That's the foundation, it's non-negotiable. But what what you described even coming from the **חסידים** about needing to know **כל** **התורה** and that level of being **שקוע** in learning and that **התמדה** and that being the basis.

How many people listening to you to us right now say that's not me, that can never be me. I I can't and don't have what it takes to do that. I guess I can't be an **איד**. I guess there's no room for me in that picture or vision of **אידישקייט**.

And and isn't there the not alternative because they're not conflicting, it's just a question of where the emphasis is. Doesn't that scare off or doesn't that marginalize or eliminate a segment or a demographic who say, I don't have those **כווחות**, I don't have that capacity? Okay, good point. Let's talk about **תפילין** for a moment. Everybody every male Jew would have to put on **תפילין** whether you feel like it or not, that's non-negotiable.

So there's there is a primary **מצווה**. That **מצווה** is **תלמוד תורה**. Everybody agrees about that. Now how much time should you spend, how much of your day should be allotted?

But there is no question that in some significant way every male Jew has to try his best to connect to the tree of life and immerse himself, whether it's five minutes a day, ten minutes a day, or most of the day, תלמוד תורה.

That doesn't mean the recipe is exactly the same for everyone. People could choose what part of תורה they want to learn. They could choose the style how they learn. They could choose the topics that interest them.

There is a lot of personal there is a lot of room left for personal preference. But nevertheless, a person can't say, well, you know, I really connect with דאווענען or I really connect with חסד, therefore I'm going to make that the main my main avenue of connecting to הקדוש ברוך הוא. That amount of personal choice has not been given to us. Not because השם is not doesn't recognize our inclination, but because there are certain realities of what does bring us closest to השם.

So in other words, there is a lot of flexibility, there is a lot of independent choice, but it's it would have to be similar it could be considered similar to a diet. Every diet has to have protein, every diet has to have carbs, every diet has to have a balanced diet has certain components to it. Everybody's going to choose a particular diet that works for them. But if a person just has one and doesn't have the other, then they're imbalanced, then it's not a healthy version.

So there is a lot of room left for personal decision. Nevertheless, there are certain fundamental aspects of עבודת השם that are not up to our personal choice because they're certain realities of creation and life in general. So how how does איד know, how does somebody know if what's speaking to them? They want to פארברענגען, they want to sing, they want to be מקדש the חול with a לחיים by transforming the גשמיות into רוחניות. What's the metric? Measure? How do they know if it's authentic and genuine? How do they know if it's superficial and manufactured and fake? What does a person need to know in addition, let's assume they're קובע עתים, they're learning, they דאווען in a מנין, they're שולחן ערוך יוד, that's the basic, that's the baseline.

You got to follow הלכה but on top of that, they're drawn to certain things. Are those things ultimately legit or are they not? So let's say a person says, okay, I already learned an hour today. Now I'm drawn to פארברענגען, so that has to be measured up according to the values of תלמוד בבלי and שולחן ערוך. What exactly is drawing you to this פארברענג? You enjoy the camaraderie, okay, camaraderie is a healthy human dynamic.

You're allowed to engage in that. You're drawn to singing, you could make the case that there's a certain human need to sing, you're allowed to sing, singing on שבת honors the שבת. But ultimately, you have to make an honest assessment because if you believe that God gave the תורה to the Jewish people on סיני and He gave us מצוות and the most valuable מצוה is תלמוד תורה, so now you have to make an assessment. Is it really worthwhile to spend two hours פארברענגען at the cost of losing two hours of תלמוד תורה? Or maybe you know what, I might be able to learn for an hour of that amount of time. Focus on how valuable it is. Realize that this is the ultimate way to connect to השם. Realize the amount of שכר that's involved and if you develop the skills in learning, you'll enjoy it very much. It will elevate you, it will give you satisfaction. Could you learn an hour of that amount of time? After rethinking it, you may realize you know what, I might be able to learn for an extra twenty minutes or an extra half hour. I don't need the full two hours. And then ultimately that may lead you to continue to reassess. So the expectation, השם asks of a person what they're able to do and all human needs are taken into account.

But a person is always required to constantly reassess what's the best way to spend one's life and spend one's time. Let's look at it in a business sense. Let's say a person had a job and by doing X or by doing Y he would be making a hundred dollars an hour, two hundred dollars an hour, three hundred dollars an hour, a thousand dollars an hour. But he doesn't really feel like it.

He would rather sit back and drink a beer. So is it reasonable for him to say you know I don't really want to put the work in, I would rather take it easy and enjoy myself? Is he allowed to do that? Sure, it's a free country, but it's not a smart choice. So why would the world of רוחניות be any different? Are you allowed to just hang around Friday night and sing and drink? Is there some value to that? Yeah. Is it a good decision? Well, put in that perspective maybe it's not.

I would ask the רב this way, I would ask you this way, clearly there's a balance and clearly there's an expectation and clearly תלמוד תורה כנגד כולם, of course, and I agree with you, I'm trying to sort of challenge both sides of this and see where we're at. What would you say though, that when we hold the standard so high that everything a person is doing they say I could and should be learning instead? And the person knows they're not capable and now they're racked with guilt, with shame, now they feel inauthentic, now they feel a failure in עבודת השם because they don't have that capacity, they don't

measure up and they can't be learning or they can't be learning at that high level and now they're just so guilty of whatever else they're doing even if there is an element or component of serving השם in it. So aren't we worried about creating also a performative אידישקייט where people look at an expectation or demand of them, they're going through the motions, they're in a system that's demanding they learn, learn certain hours, look a certain way, they're performing, they're wearing a costume, they're on a performative אידישקייט, but they're not being authentic to themselves and they're not authentically in a relationship with the רבונו של עולם and everything they're doing is either out of guilt or shame or they're not doing it anymore because they can no longer live with that guilt and shame. Wouldn't it also be helpful to give an outlet and encouragement and take away judgment and allow the person who says I'm doing what I think is the best I can, I could always push a little bit more, but I want to also be in the other time not made to feel guilt or shame that that's also a healthy expression of השם too. עבודת השם.

Yeah, and there's always a danger that expectation could bring to guilt. Guilt is not, there's no expectation of guilt or desire of guilt and guilt is different than חרטה and it's a deterrent in עבודת השם. And by the way, nothing we said is connected in any way with how a person is supposed to look or dress. You know, the requirements of עבודת השם are specifically we were discussing תלמוד תורה, we're not discussing the costume a person wears, which is not relevant.

And you know it's interesting, one of the songs, one of the popular songs was a quote from האריאל from ר' חיים ויטאל that a small act that we do in our generation is the equivalent of the greatest מצוות of He was the first one who brought that idea to the forefront. He writes this in פרשת שלח. And he himself writes that if a student studies the words of ראשון and tries to understand the words of the ראשון, and he may not even understand these words at all, in the eyes of שמים, he may be on a much higher pedestal even than the ראשון himself. And רב ירוחם says we don't like to talk about this too much, we don't want to overinflate our own value, but if you find this surprising, I didn't invent this, look in רב חיים ויטאל, the אריז"ל himself told this to him, and he quotes רב חיים ויטאל.

So this messaging is from the ישיבה world, this messaging is from the התורה, as they call it. But it became popularized in a song. So of course there's a danger and like you say, everything is a balance. You don't want to water down the standard, though.

The alternative is to start recognizing that other forms of, of course we don't expect a young student to be engrossed 24 hours a day or 12 hours a day or above and beyond what they're capable of. But that doesn't mean we want to water down the standard. So there has to be a balance of recognizing what the true standard is, and at the same time, recognizing where a person is holding in life. And there are many healthy outlets and they don't have to be always specifically connected to עבודת השם.

In a certain sense, wouldn't it be healthier if somebody said, you know, I can't learn right now, I'm going to go jogging. So is it healthier to sit around and eat chickpeas and drink alcohol and convince yourself somehow I'm sanctifying the mundane, is that, is that healthier? Maybe it's healthier to go out and take a jog and recognize this is not specifically עבודת השם, but I need to clear my mind to be able to apply myself when I'm ready to be fully authentic avenues of עבודת השם. So it's a balance both ways. But I don't think the answer would be to water down what the standard is.

Again, this is not to say that I will say on both sides, there was a refrain, this is the only way השם wants to be close to you. I think that's a little bit, or more than a little bit exaggerated. Every מצוה is a way of connecting to הקדוש ברוך הוא, whether it's דאווענינג, whether it's חסד, whether it's אהבת השם, whether it's שילוח הקן, whether it's not wearing שעטנז. These are all ways of coming close to השם.

What they're mixing up is that תלמוד תורה specifically is needed to combat the יצר הרע and other forms of עבודת השם do not necessarily combat the יצר הרע. So there was some conflation over there. But to say that it's the only way השם wants to be close to you, that's a bit, that's a bit harsh. I think that's a great place to leave it Rabbi גלאטשטיין.

The question, your emphasis on balance, needing elements and components of all, finding the balance which was missing in this conversation and in those videos, which intentionally lack balance because they're coming sort to attack and criticize, not to lift up and build. So that's a great place to leave it Rabbi גלאטשטיין, thank you so much for your time, your insight and your perspective. Thanks for having me. We're joined now by Rabbi יעקב דנישבסקי, the עבודת הלב of רב in Chicago, author most notably of the amazing book, I might add, Attached, as well as his forthcoming ספר, the Attached וקראת הגדה, לשבת עונג.

He hosts the Attached Life podcast. He's also a licensed clinical social worker and the founder of Mind Body Therapy in Chicago. Rabbi יעקב, thank you so much for joining us. Thank you.

So Rabbi יעקב, we're discussing, this was precipitated by an exchange perhaps of videos online or that made their rounds. Obviously we don't want to speak about it specifically, I don't know who produced them, I don't know who put them out, and that's not really the topic, but it did raise a bigger or broader questions which I think are worthwhile. Since the days of the original tension between the חסידים and the מתנגדים, a debate between where the emphasis should be in our עבודת השם, that conversation has continued in many different forms and among different populations and in different places. And in some ways, this seems like simply the latest regurgitation of this age-old debate in which the answer is somewhere in between.

So the video or one of them formulated, while not speaking about it specifically, but it gives us some questions or language. An אמת'ע איד, what does an אמת'ע איד look like? So to you, what would be the description of an אמת'ע איד? Is that even an appropriate term to use to describe a Jew? I mean, I think striving for אמת is definitely an appropriate term to describe somebody who's trying to serve השם properly. It's definitely something to strive for. I think in terms of trying to figure out what that means for each person, and in the context of this topic, I think of a very...

insightful קונטרס that was brought from the מדרש of רב איתמר מורגנשטרן and based on שיעורים of his, where he talks about an idea that comes from the רמח"ל and from the אריז"ל and brought down in a way that I think is more understandable for us in this קונטרס, where he talks about two different types of people, two different types of נשמות. What is referred to as נשמות of רחל and נשמות of לאה. And he describes that these two types of נשמות are fundamentally very, very different.

נשמות of רחל are the types of people who naturally, by their nature, by their שורש נשמה, their טבע, they're very wired spiritually are such that they want to know the why behind things.

They want to do things from a place of feeling connected to a deeper sense of meaning, to a deeper sense of inspiration, feeling uplifted. They want to have that kind of experience of what they're doing. In contrast with that, the נשמות of what we would call the נשמות of לאה are people who, by their nature, are not necessarily as drawn to that type of experiential way of doing things or that way of trying to understand what's behind things. Instead, they're much more focused on what am I supposed to do? What's the right way to do it? I want to know the details and I'm going to go ahead and

execute.

The נשמות of לאה are by nature people who are typically more disciplined, more consistent, and a little bit more, let's say, even-keeled in their disposition. So this conversation might be more connected to a person's שורש נשמה, how they were composed, comprised, but everyone needs both, right? Meaning, even if you're into discipline, you need a deeper meaning, deeper reasons, your life will be enriched if you plumb those. And even if you love deeper reasons, even without that, you still have to be disciplined and do what's asked of you, correct? Exactly. So what רב איתמר does in this קונטרס is he says that a person needs to essentially, I would boil it down to kind of three things.

A person needs to first identify what their type of נשמה is, who they are, which kind, and it's a spectrum, it's not all or nothing, but where do they lean? And so that's step one. Step two would be that you need to then see that as being a לכתחילה. You need to fully embrace the nature of your נשמה because that's the נשמה that השם brought down into the world for you to be servant with. But then, and this is to your point, number three is you then need to, in addition to kind of running forward as a לכתחילה with the type of נשמה you are, you need to then also take what he calls the כלים of the other side, the other type of נשמה.

Not that you need to become the other נשמה, but the person who is drawn after inspiration needs to also work on how do I bring that inspiration into a place of discipline? And the person who's by nature more, let me do what I'm supposed to do, needs to also bring somewhat into their life a deeper sense of connection. And so everyone needs, everyone needs to round out the whole picture of what it really means to be an עובד השם. So talk to me about what does it mean to be going deeper and looking for the reasons and having that שורש נשמה? Because I think some of the concern on the conversation revolves around what people perceive are superficial spiritual practices. They're sort of shortcuts or סגולות or fads or fun.

And it's not a debate between the discipline of doing the מצווה or learning and studying the פנימיות המצווה. I think what people maybe reacting to a part of the conversation revolves around what are some of the shortcuts, right? Taking trips to certain locations, getting ברכות from certain people, פארברענגינג with לחיים and singing and dancing, all which have a place in השם, עבודת השם, but they really have to be built upon a foundation of the core, which is what the conversation is, that the אמתער ייד opens a ערוך שלחן, listens

to חז"ל. It's not just about תורה learning versus other עבודה. It's about where is the anchor and where is the core, what is central and what's built upon it.

So do you have that concern that there's been the introduction of some superficiality within השם, עבודת השם, all under the guise of a sense of פנימיות? I definitely have the concern that there's superficiality in השם, עבודת השם, but I wouldn't personally limit that to one group or another. I think within the world of, let's again to use this terminology, within the world of לאה נשמות, there are people that can do it in a deep way and in a way that is לשם שמים and holistic and is when I say holistic, I mean that it's well-rounded and therefore it's not caught in the trappings of just what's easy and superficial. And I think in the world of the רחל נשמות, there are people who do it in a way that is well-rounded and לשם שמים and deep and they're working hard, and there are those who are not. But I think that's...

across the board on all in all of humanity in general, you know, people I don't think that's unique to one group or another. So where do the רחל and לאה נשמות overlap? In other words, in the average day of someone whether they're רחל or they're לאה, what are the core components? Because we're talking about a real אמת'דיקער ייד and the יום הדין that when we appear before the עולם של רבנו, if one even believes that's the way that we should formulate our life out of the fear of the יום הדין or the accountability or consequence of it. But what will a רחל and a לאה life and lifestyle both have in common even if there's a different emphasis for each? Where will they overlap in what their day will look like? Yeah, I mean ברוך השם I think that that question is fairly easy to answer right? Because a רחל and a לאה נשמה are both following the ערוך שלחן and are both trying to do their best to be מצות תרי"ג מקיים and etc. and all that follows from that and the difference is going to be in some emphasis on how they do that and how much time is allotted to this aspect of עבודת השם versus how much time is allotted to that aspect and how they, you know, how they do it on a on a, you know, quantitatively and in inner level or what the emphasis is. But without question of course the mainstay of what a person is doing is going to be, you know, somebody who's a ייד פרום is going to look is going to look the same.

And the mainstay will incorporate a learning schedule, דאווענען, מנין, some of the foundation and some of the building blocks and then on top of that it will be expressed differently? Yeah but even within the building blocks they can be different,

right? So תורה learning but what does that mean? It can be, you know, what what a person is learning can be different for different people.

אין אדם לומד אלא במקום שלבו חפץ. Different people will find themselves learning different things. How much time they're spending learning.

And similarly for דאווענען, different people will דאווענען with different styles of מנינים, different different emphasis on on how much time they spend דאווענען or how they דאווענען. So I think it's I think it permeates everything. The body of of what we're doing will primarily look the same, but will have different emphasis, just like כשם שפרצופיהם שונים כך. Right, and and all the מפרשים explain when דעותיהם שונות, excuse me, כך דעותיהם שונות. Right, and and all the מפרשים explain when משה רבינו is supposed to pick the next leader and it's יהושע, the terminology used is אלקי הרוחות, right? Is that to be to be the leader you need to understand the the difference in in each person.

So different people are are here in the world to do a different עבודה and all those עבודות are filtered through having a רבי and filtered through הלכה, but within that that's going to that that's going to now manifest into the world in a variety of different ways for what each person's job here in this world is. So so if a person אמת'דיקער ייד אמת'דיקער ייד opens the שלחן ערוך like their זיידעס did and that's on the יום הדין what השם wants. If if a person doesn't open the שלחן ערוך, they're not well-versed, they're not familiar, they haven't taken a deep dive in הלכות שבת, I'm not even speaking in esoteric areas of הלכה, they're not trying to training to be פוסקים necessarily, but like you know every ייד needs to know how do you know what ברכות to make, how do you know how to keep שבת?

חפץ חיים says in his introduction that unless you learn הלכות שבת, it's going to be almost impossible to observe it and keep it. So if a person is not opening their שלחן ערוך and instead they're skipping to other forms of עבודה, expressions of עבודה, is is are they not אמת? I mean you could say the inverse too.

If the person is consumed entirely in the שלחן ערוך, it's always open and wide open in front of them, but it's dry הלכה, it's a system of minutiae and law, but it's not informed and inspired by depth and profundity and feeling and purpose, are they אמת? Right, right, it's like the just as a as a example or a משל for this, so you know the famous question about, you know, two days of ארץ לארץ keeping two days of טוב when they're in ארץ ישראל, right? So if some so the mainstream פסק seems pretty simple that a

person's supposed to keep two days of יום טוב. But some people are coming from homes where their parents maybe maybe didn't, don't, and if you're with your family but you realize you probably should and they're not, so what should you do? So רב שלמה זלמן brings up the fact, to be perfect honest I don't remember exactly what he says הלכה למעשה, but he brings up the consideration of of the fact that on the one hand in terms of טוב it's going to be we should be מחמיר that מעיקר הדין a person should be keeping two. But then you might bring up the fact that there is ואם and הלכות כיבוד אב and maybe that's going to now it's the חומרא in טוב יום הלכות will be a קולא in אב כיבוד ואם and vice versa, so it's not so simple. So yeah, we can point to any one area, but we're we are all finite people and being finite means that any time that you are that you're choosing to emphasize one thing, you are by definition de-emphasizing...

emphasizing the other thing, right? So like they point out that the word decide, to decide something, has the suffix C-I-D-E, which is like homicide, genocide, suicide. Because to decide means to kill something. When you choose X, you've now diminished Y, right? So of course, if there's השם ברוך there's a million things in יידישקייט to emphasize. And certain people will emphasize one thing, but by definition when they do that, they're actually de-emphasizing something else and vice versa.

There's no way to escape that. So the whole question is just which things do we emphasize more, which things do we emphasize less? And again, without a question that all has to be within the framework of having a רבי and having and הלכה. But within that there's still a huge open canvas of trying to figure out so what do we emphasize, what do we not emphasize? And I think again, that's where it comes down to each person has to have a רבי and each person has to understand themselves and their עבודה and it needs to be figured out for each person and what the emphasis and de-emphasizing חס ושלום doesn't ever mean cutting something out. It doesn't mean that anything can be cut out, but which things get more of the focus and which things get less of the focus.

So I think one of the most important things that you said is a person has to know themselves.

דע את עצמך, what's your הנשמה שורש, where are you drawn? How does someone know if where they're drawn is authentic and real or it's counterfeit? Maybe what is inspiring for them, what feels real, what makes them feel loved by השם, is feel-good. Maybe it's fleeting. Maybe it's a counterfeit experience.

Maybe it's actually just self-serving as opposed to authentic. How does a person know if what they're feeling is within the framework, is real, even if it's one particular emphasis or the other? And can a person's שורש הנשמה shift? If they start one day, if enough videos are put out that make them feel criticized or that they're not going to succeed on יום הדין, can a person's שורש הנשמה shift? I don't think the שורש הנשמה can shift, but I think they can shift away from their שורש הנשמה. But how do you know that it's real? I would say two things. First off, I want to just stop on the assumption of the framing in the question a little bit.

I don't think that the experience of something feeling good is a סימן מובהק that it's a fake. I think sometimes that can be thrown around. There's nothing wrong with something feeling good in עבודת השם. Actually, the רמבם writes in ספר המצוות in the מצוה of אהבת השם, that you actually haven't been יוצא the מצוה of אהבת השם until you experience הנאה in the deepest way, until you're experiencing a pleasure, that there's actually a pleasure in the experience of הקדוש ברוך הוא.

So the fact that something feels good is not a פסול or a פגם or a question mark. It's just that I have to also be able to do it when it doesn't feel good. But it's allowed to feel good and it should feel good.

עונג אלוקי.

It's supposed to. It's supposed to. It's supposed to. There's something missing if it doesn't. Again, it doesn't mean it's supposed to always feel good. But if it's not feeling good a very substantive amount of the time, there's something something needs to be looked at. Do you think it's important, and maybe we'll end with this, thank you for your time רבי יעקב, do you think it's important for the רך personalities to each not only promote what feels more natural to them, what they're drawn to, but also to demonstrate their commitment sort of the other so that it's clear to all that there is a balance? In these movements which are emphasizing different parts of עבודה and beautiful, but imagine if the one side that was filled with energy and enthusiasm and שמחה and thank you also clearly promoted and reinforced the importance of opening the שולחן ערוך and opening the גמרא and being part of the מסורה and if the other side also focused not only on clocking the hours of learning and התמדה but also on the depth of the פנימיות and the עבודה and the experience. Would that be something important that you'd call for or welcome? I think it would be important, but I actually the truth is I think it's already there. I really do think that the obviously there's exceptions to everything, but by and large, I think the groups that are again let's let's call it the רכות הנשמות that are doing more of

that kind of positively oriented שמחה, inspiration type things, I think they are opening the שולחן ערוך and I think that they are talking about שולחן ערוך and I think that they are talking about being consistent and being grounded in all of those things and I also think that the groups that are that are spending the majority of the time in the סוגיות in גמרא and working working through through through וכולי and all of that, I think they also are talking about שמחה and I think that they are talking positively and I think that they are talking about how to have a תפילה that's actually coming from the לב and עבודת הלב and I think both sides are arguing that. I just think that some of the representation of the other side sometimes by whatever silliness is going on will caricatureize different things, but I actually think both sides are doing a fairly good job at keeping grounded. That is a very positive way to look at it.

There definitely are agitators. And I guess the real final question, if you could give a message, again, I don't know who's producing and we don't want to make it specifically about that, but if you could give a message to whoever's behind videos or public statements that are trying to maybe vilify the other or delegitimize the other to both sides, what would your message be? I don't really have a message for whatever, whatever that is, but I would just end off by saying to your previous question that I think I think the main thing is, even before what we promote, is going back to what I started with, this רחל of קונטרס and לאה, is that what רב איתמר is writing about here is that the רחל needs to work on attaining for themselves some of the כלים of לאה and לאה needs to work on himself on bringing in some of the כלים of רחל. So whichever way you're naturally drawn, again, see that as a לכתחילה and run with that, that's your עבודה, but at the same time you also need to bring in some of whatever is less natural for you and round out the picture לשם שמים. That is a beautiful, beautiful perspective and charge to all of us to react to what's going on, to be inspired in that way.

Rabbi יעקב Danishefsky, thank you so much for joining us. Thank you.